

State is facing greater fire peril

Trump’s cuts, changes at U.S. Forest Service, NOAA and FEMA could make the 2025 season even worse.

By HAYLEY SMITH

As California continues to reel from the historic firestorm that decimated portions of Los Angeles County in January, the state is now facing the prospect of an exceptionally active wild-fire season fueled by hot, dry conditions. It may not be ready: Experts say sweeping changes at federal agencies that play key roles in California’s wildfire preparation and response could make a challenging season even worse.

The latest forecast from the National Interagency Fire Center calls for above-normal fire activity across much of California and the Northwest through September. The government outlook warns of “significant fire potential” in Northern California, the Sierra Nevada and several of the state’s coastal areas due largely to a pronounced warm and dry trend.

The forecast arrives as the Trump administration is enacting budget cuts, layoffs, office closures and restructuring at the U.S. Forest Service, the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and the Federal Emergency Management Agency. President Trump has said the changes will help eliminate federal waste and save Americans’ tax dollars.

However, these three agencies are critical components of California’s wildfire response capabilities, from forecasting and forest management to firefighting and disaster relief. Weakening them at the start of fire season — and at a moment when human-caused climate change is driving larger and more destructive blazes [See Wildfires, A7]



ANDREW D. BERNSTEIN NBAE via Getty Images
KOBE BRYANT congratulates Lakers owner Jerry Buss after he receives a championship ring Oct. 26, 2010.

Dodgers chairman to buy Lakers majority ownership

The deal, valuing the team at record \$10 billion, will end longtime family-run control of storied basketball franchise

By DAN WOIKE AND BILL SHAIKIN

The Los Angeles Lakers, a family-run business since Jerry Buss purchased the franchise in 1979, will be sold to Dodgers controlling owner Mark Walter and TWG Global, according to multiple people briefed on the deal.

The deal is expected to occur with the Lakers’ valuation being about \$10 billion — a record for a professional sports franchise.

Walter will now lead the city’s two premier professional sports teams.

Control of the Lakers went into a family trust after Buss died in 2013, with daughter Jeanie Buss operating as the team’s governor. The structure of the trust meant the majority of Buss’ six children — Johnny, Jim, Jeanie, Janie, Joey and Jesse — would need to agree for a sale to occur.

The Lakers didn’t respond to requests for comment.

The structure of the family trust, according to people familiar with it, doesn’t [See Lakers, A11]



FREDERIC J. BROWN AFP via Getty Images
MARK WALTER’S deal Wednesday was a surprise in NBA circles.

Raids turning hubs to ghost towns

Amid ICE detentions, bustling immigrant nerve centers across L.A. see foot traffic drop in recent days.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ AND GRACE TOOHEY

With federal immigration sweeps showing no signs of slowing across Southern California, there is growing concern from top officials, spiritual leaders and business owners that a climate of fear is sending more people underground and changing the rhythm of city life.

Once-bustling immigrant hubs, including MacArthur Park, the Fashion District, downtown’s produce market and areas of the Eastside have seen a noticeable reduction in foot traffic over the last week, with some businesses forced to close as a result.

It comes as social media are rife with videos of people spotting immigration agents at shopping centers, markets and neighborhood streets, and capturing federal agents making arrests at swap meets, car washes and other businesses.

Los Angeles Archbishop José H. Gomez said he has been “disturbed” by how many of these raids have been carried out, noting they’ve caused a deep panic among his majority-Latino [See Raids, A6]

Justices back states’ hormone care ban

By DAVID G. SAVAGE AND KEVIN RECTOR

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court ruled Wednesday that states may ban puberty blockers and hormone treatments for transgender teens, rejecting the claim that such gender-based discrimination is unconstitutional.

In a 6-3 decision, the court’s conservative majority said states are generally free to decide on proper standards of medical care.

Chief Justice John G. Roberts Jr. said there is “an ongoing debate among medical experts regarding the risks and benefits” of hormone treatments for adolescents with gender dysphoria.

In dissent, Justice Sonia Sotomayor said the law at issue “plainly discriminates on the basis of sex. ... By retreating from meaningful judicial review exactly where it matters most, the Court abandons transgender children and their families to political whims.” Justices Elena Kagan and Ketanji Brown Jackson agreed.

Wednesday’s decision highlights the nation’s sharp right turn in the last year on transgender rights and gender-affirming care and the divide among states. [See Hormones, A6]

Mixed signals over ICE sweeps perplex growers, workers

They aren’t sure whether state will see more arrests during summer harvest



AL SEIB For The Times
FARMWORKERS plant rows of jalapeños in a Camarillo field on Wednesday.

By JESSICA GARRISON AND MELISSA GOMEZ

As the crucial summer harvest season gets underway in California’s vast agricultural regions, farmers and their workers say they feel whiplashed by a series of contradictory signals about how the Trump administration’s crackdown on illegal immigration might affect them.

California grows more than one-third of the country’s vegetables and more than three-quarters of the nation’s fruits and nuts in the fertile expanses of the Central Valley, Central Coast and other farming regions. The industry produced nearly \$60 billion in goods in 2023, according to

state figures — an output that depends heavily on the skilled labor of a workforce that is at least 50% undocumented, according to University of California studies.

Without workers, the juicy beefsteak tomatoes that are ripening and must be hand-harvested will rot on the vines. The yellow peaches just reaching that delicate blend of sweet and tart will fall to the ground, unpicked. Same with the melons, grapes and cherries.

That’s why, when federal immigration agents rolled into the berry fields of Oxnard last week and detained 40 farmworkers, growers up and down the state grew worried along with their workers.

[See Farms, A6]

Iran rejects U.S. calls to surrender

Trump would not say if he has decided to order a strike to stop nuclear program. **WORLD, A3**

ICE agents aren’t welcome at hotels

Protesters pressure proprietors to refuse to host immigration officials. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Trump endorses Paramount plan

President appears to approve of the merger with David Ellison’s Skydance. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 82/62. **B6**

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